

PROFILE

Political economist and postdoctoral researcher at Vrije Universiteit Brussel (VUB), where I also serve as Visiting Professor in the Faculty of Social Sciences & Solvay Business School. My research examines political polarisation, populism and democratic representation, alongside an emerging agenda on AI, technological change and societal transformation. I combine econometric analysis with computational social science to examine how political divisions and technological change shape economic behaviour and democratic outcomes.

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

- **Postdoctoral Researcher and Visiting Professor | Vrije Universiteit Brussel | 2025–present**
 - Research in political economy, polarisation and the socioeconomic implications of AI.
 - Course holder for Research Methods for Business (academic year 2025-2026).
 - Master thesis supervisor.
- **Doctoral Researcher and Teaching Assistant | Vrije Universiteit Brussel | 2019–2025**
 - Researcher in political economy, electoral choice, and polarisation.
 - Teaching assistant for microeconomics and public choice.
 - Supervised undergraduate and graduate research projects.

EDUCATION

- **PhD in Economics | Vrije Universiteit Brussel | 2019–2025**
- Thesis: Political Economy of Selection and Polarisation: Essays on Electoral Choice, Representation and Voter Turnout.
- **MSc in Applied Economics (great distinction) | Vrije Universiteit Brussel | 2017–2018**
 - Graduated with great distinction.
 - Thesis: *Unravelling the Democracy-Growth Nexus: An Empirical Analysis and Institutional Explanation* — awarded greatest distinction (17/20).
- **MicroMasters in Data, Economics, and Design of Policy | MITx | 2017**
- **BSc in Applied Economics | Vrije Universiteit Brussel | 2012–2016**

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- Al Yussef, A. Turnout and the distortion of representation: the case of electoral polarization. *Public Choice* (2026).
- Al Yussef, A., & Heyndels, B. (2025). Socioeconomic anxieties and electoral polarization: insights from Belgian federal elections at the municipal level. *Acta Politica*, 60, 524–549.
- Al Yussef, A., Heyndels, B., & Le Boulaire, P. (2023). Forever young: Relative age effects in Belgian political selection. *Kyklos*, 76(4), 859–881.

BOOK CHAPTERS

- Al Yussef, A., Heyndels, B., & Le Boulaire, P. (2021). La vie au bureau: Een case study omtrent de evolutie van het publicatiegedrag in de economische wetenschappen. In *Critical Contributions to Economics and Beyond* (pp. 2-16). [1] Lexxion.

WORKING PAPERS AND RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

- Al Yussef, A. (2025). A Political Economy of Culture Wars: Polarisation, Sticky Preferences and Mobilisation. *Working paper* [PhD Chapter].
- Al Yussef, A. (2026). Divided We Consume: Politics, Norms, and Sentiment in the Marketplace. *Research in Progress*.
- Al Yussef, A. (2026). Ambiguously human: LLMs Over-ideologize Political Statements. *Research in Progress*.
- Al Yussef, A. (2026). Coding Alone: AI and The Unravelling of Collaborative Networks. *Research in Progress*.

POSTDOCTORAL FELLOWSHIP PROPOSAL

- F.R.S.–FNRS postdoctoral fellowship application | 2026

Three-year proposal on political polarisation, normative fragmentation and economic behaviour, submitted to the Fund for Scientific Research (F.R.S.–FNRS). Evaluation: A–; recommended for funding but not funded due to budget constraints.

TEACHING AND SUPERVISION

Vrije Universiteit Brussel, Faculty of Social Sciences & Solvay Business School

- Master's Dissertation | Thesis Supervisor | 2025-present

- I supervise master's students throughout the research process, from defining research problems and questions, reviewing the literature and developing theoretical frameworks, to designing empirical strategies, collecting and analysing data, and writing their dissertations.

- Research Methods for Business | Course Holder | 2025–2026

Teaching in English on research design, qualitative and quantitative methods, academic writing and the critical assessment of empirical evidence.

- Microeconomics and Public Choice | Teaching Assistant | 2019–2025

Teaching across bachelor's, bridging and master's programmes. Responsibilities included exercise sessions, assessment and feedback.

- Undergraduate Research Supervision | Research Supervisor | 2019-2025

Supervision of students in Business Engineering, International Management and Applied Economics, in developing and executing undergraduate research projects. Guidance on research questions, conceptual frameworks, empirical design and data analysis.

METHODS AND COMPUTATIONAL SKILLS

- **Econometrics:** Applied econometrics and causal inference, randomised controlled trials, instrumental variables and regression discontinuity designs.
- **Computational methods:** Computational social science; natural language processing (NLP); large language models (LLMs); machine learning.
- **Programming and data tools:** R, Python, Power BI and data visualisation.

Additional Methodological Training

- Barcelona School of Economics | Summer School | June 2022

- Two-week training in natural language processing and deep learning.

CONFERENCE & WORKSHOP PRESENTATIONS

- DemoTrans workshop on Democracy, Globalisation and the Future of Governance, KU Leuven (September 2026)
- DemoTrans Conference on Democracy, Globalisation and the Future of Governance, KU Leuven (May 2026)
- European Public Choice Society Meeting, Madrid (March 2026)
- 4th RUCAM Political Economy Workshop, Radboud University Nijmegen (August 2025)
- 3rd RUCAM Political Economy Workshop, Radboud University Nijmegen (August 2024)
- ECPR General Conference, Dublin (August 2024)
- The 6th International Conference on European Economics and Politics, ETH Zurich (June 2024)
- Norwegian Business School (BI), Economics Seminar, Bergen (May 2024)
- VUB APEC Seminar, Brussels (February 2024)

RESEARCH STAYS

- Research Stay at Institute for Economic Analysis (IAE), Barcelona (2025)
 - o Hosted by Prof. Dr. Hannes Mueller
- Research Stay at Norwegian Business School (BI), Bergen (2024)
 - o Hosted by Prof. Dr. Benny Geys

LANGUAGES

- English (C2), Dutch (C2), French (B1/B2), German (Basic), Kurdish (native), Arabic (native).

ACADEMIC SERVICE

- Member, Research Council, Faculty of Social Sciences and Solvay Business School (2023–Present)
- Member, Curriculum Council, Faculty of Social Sciences and Solvay Business School (2021–2025)

REFeree SERVICE

- *Public Finance Review* (Sage); *De Economist* (Springer Nature); *Public Choice* (Springer Nature);

INTERESTS AND HOBBIES

- I enjoy reading, hiking, playing guitar and lute, painting and illustration.

REFERENCES

- Prof. Dr. Pierre-Guillaume Méon—Université Libre de Bruxelles – p-guillaume.meon@ulb.be
- Prof. Dr. Benny Geys – Norwegian Business School – benny.geys@bi.no
- Prof. Dr. Eva Van Belle – Vrije Universiteit Brussel – eva.van.belle@vub.be
- Prof. Dr. Filip Van Droogenbroeck – Vrije Universiteit Brussel – filip.van.droogenbroeck@vub.be
- Prof. Dr. Bruno Heyndels—Vrije Universiteit Brussel—Bruno.Heyndels@vub.be